CFLMUN'26

Addressing the Role of Organized Crime in Drug Trafficking

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STUDY GUIDE

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1. LETTER FROM THE SECRETARY GENERAL

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to CFLMUN'26, everyone! My name is Sümeyra, and I have the honour of serving as the Secretary General at this conference. I'm filled with excitement and happiness. Also, I'd like to thank my Head of Academy Belinay Takcı, my Under Secretary General Alya Selen Gürbüz and my academic assistant Atalay Uras Yeltekin for helping to organize the committee.

In the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, UNODC, you will interpret the issue of drug trafficking, which is one of the important problems of today, as a national eye.

Also, I want to say thank you to each and every one of you for choosing to be a part of this committee. Your presence and participation are what will make it truly meaningful. I look forward to seeing you all between May 1st and 3rd, ready to challenge perspectives, defend positions, and most importantly, enjoy the experience.

Wishing you all the best of luck. Let's shape the future in the light of diplomacy!

Warm regards,

Sümeyra Gülsüm Çolak

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2. LETTER FROM THE HEAD OF ACADEMY

Distinguished delegates,

It is a great honour to welcome you to the first edition of CFLMUN. Over the course of this conference, you will engage in thoughtful debate, share perspectives, and develop solutions to complex global issues. In a world shaped by conflict and uncertainty, your voice carries weight. The responsibility to think critically and act thoughtfully belongs to you. As delegates, you are not only participants in debate, but contributors to ideas that shape perspectives beyond this room.

Your dedication to preparing for this conference already shows your commitment to building a better future. Use this opportunity to challenge your critical thinking, refine your voice, and explore perspectives different from your own. We look forward to seeing the creativity, determination, and insight you bring to your committees.

It's essential not to forget that the experience you acquire here will stay with you for years to come. Make the most of every moment, both inside and outside your committee sessions. Do not hesitate to seek guidance whenever you need it.

Your seat is ready. We are eager to hear your ideas.

Sincerely,

Belinay Takcı

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3. LETTER FROM THE ACADEMIC ASSISTANT OF UNODC

Dear delegates,

It is my great pleasure to welcome all of you to CFLMUN26 as the academic assistant of UNODC. I am really excited to witness my delegates debate global issues. I hope that in this conference you will not only gain awareness of organized crimes but also make unforgettable memories and connections. Our agenda, "Organized Crimes," is an active issue that governments are dealing with to find proper solutions. I hope that in this study guide, we have done our best while preparing it. I expect my delegates to understand the importance of the agenda and solve this matter in the most effective way possible.

I sincerely hope that in these three days, CFLMUN26 will challenge you, inspire you, and leave you better equipped to contribute to a more peaceful and cooperative world. I wish you a rewarding conference.

Sincerely,

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4. INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMITTEE

a. What Is UNODC?

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) is a global leader in the fight against illicit drugs, transnational organized crime, corruption, and terrorism. UNODC's mandate focuses on combating crimes such as drug trafficking, migrant smuggling, human trafficking, corruption, and terrorism.

UNODC's activities aim to mitigate the harmful effects of corruption, illegal drugs, human trafficking, terrorism, and other forms of transnational crime on development and stability. By addressing these threats, the organization helps reduce human suffering, insecurity, and loss of life worldwide.

Operating through an extensive network of field offices and partnerships, UNODC works with governments to strengthen security, justice systems, and the rule of law. It supports states by providing data-driven research, technical assistance, legal expertise, capacity-building programs, and platforms for international cooperation.

UNODC was established in 1997 as a result of the merging of the United Nations Centre for International Crime Prevention and the United Nations International Drug Control Programme. It was established by the Secretary-General of the United Nations to enable the organization to focus and enhance its capacity to address the interrelated issues of drug control, crime, and international terrorism in all its forms.

5. INTRODUCTION TO THE AGENDA ITEM

a. What Counts as Organized Crime?

Organized crime refers to transnational, national, or local groups of centralized enterprises that engage in illegal activities, most commonly for profit. Organized crime can be defined as planned and coordinated criminal behavior conducted by people, groups, or networks working together on a continuing basis. It focuses exclusively on planned, rational acts that reflect the effort of groups of individuals; it does not include random, unplanned, individual criminal acts. Organized crime is a continuing criminal enterprise that rationally works to profit from illicit activities that are often in great public demand. A criminal organization can also be referred to as an outfit, a gangster/gang, a thug, a crime family, the mafia, a mobster/mob, a (crime) ring, or a syndicate. Organized crime has the characteristics of self-perpetuation and continuing conspiracy, the goals of profit and power, and virtual immunity from the law. In its self-perpetuation, organized crime operates in a similar manner to the corporate organization; functions proceed without interruption regardless of arrests or deaths of participants. Its structure is designed for continuous succession.

Many criminal organizations rely on fear or terror to achieve their goals and maintain control within their ranks. These groups may adopt tactics similar to those used by authoritarian regimes to maintain power. Its continuing existence is maintained through corruption of public officials and the use of intimidation, threats, or force to protect its operations. Power is manifested primarily in the corruption of political leaders and members of the criminal justice system. Fear is used to intimidate victims and witnesses, and the corruption of public officials virtually ensures immunity from serious prosecution of important members of organized crime. In 2020, 73% are believed to be involved in violent activities, ranging from assaults and extortion to shootings and homicides. High-level Mafia figures continue to remain insulated from acts of violence, often using street gang members to commit acts of intimidation, extortion, arson, and murder. Street gangs are more likely to be involved in overt violent activities that present a higher risk to public safety.

Organized crime basically supplies illegal goods and services, such as gambling, loansharking, narcotics, and prostitution. The threats cover cybercrime, drug crime, economic crime, intellectual property crime, modern slavery and human trafficking, organized immigration crime, border crime, excise evasion and tax fraud, national serious and organized crime, environmental crime, and organized crime against the benefit system. Criminal networks engage in a wide range of illicit activities, including money laundering, the illegal trade in firearms, and trafficking in humans, organs, drugs, natural resources, wildlife, and even waste. Methamphetamine continues to be one of the most significant national-level criminal market threats to communities across Canada. Cocaine remains one of the most profitable and stable illicit drug markets in Canada. Outlaw motorcycle gangs often take part in legitimate charitable events and other public relations efforts to portray themselves positively. Support clubs are an important element of organized mafia group (OMG) networks, whose members use them to traffic drugs and commit acts of violence and intimidation.

The term "transnational" highlights the fact that these criminal networks operate across borders and geographies. They are active in all countries—rich and poor, North and South, developed and developing. They illegally move people, goods, and money across borders, whether smuggling drugs from one country to another, trafficking people across continents, or laundering money through offshore accounts. Transnational organized crime is a multi-billion-dollar industry. In Africa alone, the equivalent of nearly $90 billion, or about 3.7 per cent of the continent's Gross Domestic Product (GDP), is lost yearly to illicit financial flows. Money laundering—the process of concealing the origins of illegally obtained money, turning "dirty money" into "clean money"—is a global scourge. Around $1.6 trillion, or 2.7 per cent of the global GDP, is estimated to be laundered yearly. Today's drug markets thrive online, operating through darknet marketplaces, social media platforms, and encrypted communication applications. The rise of digital currencies, such as cryptocurrencies, has created new challenges for law enforcement agencies.

The ramifications are often the same: weakened governance, corruption, lawlessness, violence, and ultimately, death and destruction. Kleptocracies, mafia states, narco-states, or narcokleptocracies are either heavily involved with organized crime

or tend to foster organized crime within their own governments. It is suspected that many members of organized crime groups are involved in areas of the public sector. Family connections, romantic relationships, and monetary gain appear to be the principal factors motivating corruption in the sector. Their operations can influence you directly. The taxes you pay can increase because of losses in revenue from things such as contraband tobacco and alcohol. Your car insurance can also cost you more when premiums increase as a result of car thefts. Private sector businesses are also exploited by OCG (Organized Crime Groups) to launder their proceeds of crime. The accommodations and food services, retail trade, transportation and warehousing, construction, and other services represent 64% of the businesses linked to OCG.

b. The Link Between Organized Crime and Drug Trafficking

Transnational organized crime, and especially its association with drug trafficking, is an outright threat for European governments and societies. The lives lost or ruined by drugs or during criminal confrontations are not only a constant and high cost for a demographically stable population but also directly or indirectly represent an economic gain for dangerous actors who challenge the authority of the state and the law from beyond its borders. No government or public would accept similar levels of casualties in peacekeeping, external attack, or terrorism, but politicians and citizens at large still entertain the ruinous belief that drug trafficking is an internal matter to be fatalistically accepted just as car accidents are.

The economic resources generated by organized crime and drug trafficking are directly and deliberately used for destabilizing the society, the political system, the administration, and the economy of a country. The corresponding effects are 'pax mafiosa,' destruction of democratic/liberal values, corruption, money laundering, and the infiltration of legitimate businesses. The transnational networks, created and sustained by this combination, attack territorial integrity both within and at the borders of a given country. Whenever organized crime controls an area, transnational organized crime has free access, and law enforcement finds a 'no-go' area or is anyhow ineffective. These areas, also called 'grey zones,' are unfortunately found in many European countries.

Leveraging the increased mobility afforded by globalization and rapid advancements in transportation and communication technologies, transnational organized crime groups now operate with unprecedented scope and sophistication. Driven by factors such as economic instability, corruption, high unemployment, educational deficiencies and institutional vulnerabilities, organized crime constitutes one of the most complex and pressing threats to national, regional, and international security. Organized criminal groups are typically engaged in a range of illicit activities, including trafficking of narcotic substances, smuggling of migrants, firearms and ammunition, cultural property, counterfeit goods, tobacco, and alcohol. They are also actively involved in corruption, financial crimes, and laundering of criminal proceeds. In recent years, their operations have increasingly extended into cyberspace, exploiting digital platforms to perpetrate information technology-related offenses.

Transnational organized crime, drug trafficking, and international terrorism, which are described as “new risks” or “non-state actors,” are, today, major challenges for internal and international security and stability. Although these three risks are not new, they have become global, multidimensional, and complicated. There is no doubt whatsoever that there is a strong linkage between non-state actors and national, regional, and international security issues. All countries are affected by the new risks; transnational organized crime and illicit drug trafficking, like mushrooms, are pervasive, and no country is immune from these. Transnational organized crime facilitates illegal drugs and immigration and human trafficking, which can be thought of as a new form of slavery. Ordinary citizens are directly affected by the mentioned risks, and their political choices are affected as well; if security becomes an obsession for the electorate and governments, rational and tolerant choices might be wishful thinking.

The strategic feature of non-state actors is being increasingly underlined by global actors like the United Nations, the European Union, and other security organizations. Illicit drugs and their trafficking could contribute to terrorism in at least five distinct ways: they supply cash for terrorism; they create chaos in countries where drugs are produced, through which they pass, or in which they are sold; they generate corruption in law enforcement, military, and other governmental institutions; they provide services useful for terrorist actions and movements of personnel; and they support a common infrastructure, such as smuggling capabilities, illicit arms acquisition, or money laundering. The problem of arms trafficking is multidimensional, as firearms are manufactured and traded both licitly and illicitly. Most firearms are produced legally and then diverted into the illicit market, which increases the power of organized criminal groups and makes identification and tracing very complex.

6. KEY TERMS

Transnational Organized Crime (TOC): Transnational organized crime is organized crime coordinated across national borders, involving groups or markets of individuals working in more than one country to plan and execute illegal business ventures. To achieve their goals, these criminal groups use systematic violence and corruption. Common transnational organized crimes include conveying drugs, conveying arms, toxic waste disposal, materials theft and poaching.

Drug Trafficking: Drug trafficking is a global illicit trade involving the cultivation, manufacture, distribution and sale of substances which are subject to drug prohibition laws.

Pax Mafiosa: The Pax Mafiosa is a term describing a state of relative non-violence in the territories of organized crime groups caused by agreements not to interfere in criminal activities.

Money Laundering: Money laundering is the process of illegally concealing the origin of money obtained from illicit activities such as drug trafficking, sex work, terrorism, corruption and converting the funds into a seemingly legitimate source, usually through a front organization.

Grey Zones: Geographic areas or urban sectors where the state has lost its monopoly on power, resulting in a vacuum of authority. In these zones, organized crime groups or non-state actors take over governance, law enforcement, and social control.

Kleptocracy: A system of governance where leaders embezzle state funds and national resources for personal wealth. It is often characterized by the absence of democratic oversight and the subversion of the rule of law.

Narco-State / Narcokleptocracy: A narcokleptocracy is a society in which criminals involved in the trade of narcotics have undue influence on the governance of a state.

Illicit Financial Flows: Illicit financial flows refer to the movement of money across borders that is illegal in its source, its transfer, or its use. It also has longstanding concerns with flows that are not strictly illegal but are associated with tax avoidance.

Non-State Actors: Non-state actors (NSA) are entities that participate or act in international relations. They are organizations with sufficient power to influence and cause a change even though they do not belong to any established institution of a state.

OCG: A group of people working together on a continual basis to plan and co-ordinate criminal behaviour and conduct. Their motivation is often, but not always, financial gain.

Shell Corporations: A shell corporation is a company or corporation with no significant assets or operations, often formed to obtain financing before beginning business. Shell companies were primarily vehicles for lawfully hiding the identity of their beneficial owners, and this is still their defining feature due to the loopholes in global corporate transparency initiatives.

Synthetic Drugs: Synthetic Drugs are chemically manufactured substances designed to mimic the effects of traditional illicit drugs like cocaine or cannabis. They lack quality control and scientific research, causing their chemical composition and long-term health risks to remain largely unknown and unpredictable.

7. KEY PLAYERS

a) Major Organizations (Cartels and Syndicates)

Major drug trafficking organizations operate as sophisticated "mini-states" with paramilitary power. While these syndicates have global reach, their evolution from centralized hierarchies to complex criminal networks is most clearly demonstrated through the current landscapes of Colombia and Mexico.

COLOMBIA

The country's relationship with drug trafficking began in the 1970s, when farmers in northern Colombia began planting marijuana as a much more lucrative alternative to legal crops. This period was known as the "Bonanza Marimbera". Marijuana was shipped to the United States through networks involving Colombians and Americans, some of whom had come to Colombia in the 1960s with the Peace Corps. The smuggling of marijuana from Colombia to the United States laid the groundwork for the trafficking of other drugs such as cocaine.

In the 1980s, drug traffickers like Escobar even entered politics, with Escobar becoming a member of the Colombian Congress. Following Escobar's death in 1993, the landscape fragmented. Groups like the FARC (guerrilla) and the AUC (paramilitary) began using drug trafficking as a primary financial engine.

Today, the scene is dominated by "criminal hybrids" known as BACRIM (Bandas Criminales). Key current actors include:

The Gaitanistas (AGC): Formed by former paramilitary members.

FARC Dissidents: Specifically the Estado Mayor Central (EMC) and the Second Marquetalia, who control border territories and production chains.

ELN: A guerrilla group that has gained considerable territorial power in the post-peace agreement vacuum.

MEXICO

Mexico's role in organized crime has been defined by its neighbor, the United States, the most powerful consumer economy in the world. The countries' 3,141-kilometer border is one of the most active contraband routes on the planet. For two centuries, entrepreneurs and contraband traders have moved goods across the vast border region. Migrants too have long crossed the·border, many remaining in places like California where agricultural work was steady.

The modern history of drug trafficking in Mexico dates back to the early 20th Century, when traditional marijuana production began to feed a growing consumer market among soldiers and farmers fighting during the Revolution. Around the same time, small-scale poppy production grew due to an increasing global demand for opiates, such as morphine and heroin, particularly from the United States, as a painkiller for soldiers wounded in World War I and, later, in World War II.

Many of the large and powerful drug cartels that once dominated Mexico's underworld are now shadows of their former selves. The main leaders of the Gulf Cartel, the Beltrán Leyva Organization, the Zetas, Familia Michoacana, the Juárez Cartel, the Tijuana Cartel, and the Knights Templar have been killed or arrested in past years, leaving their organizations in varying states of decline. The exception is the Sinaloa Cartel, which despite the recapture of El Chapo remains the most prolific drug trafficking organization in the Western Hemisphere. However, it now operates as a network of criminal partners rather than through a hierarchical structure.

Today, the scene is dominated by a complex balance of power between established networks and emerging militarized factions with key factors such as:

Sinaloa Cartel: The most prolific drug trafficking organization in the Western Hemisphere; it now operates as a network of criminal partners rather than through a hierarchical structure.

Jalisco Cartel New Generation (CJNG): A "giant" of drug trafficking that uses a mixture of ruthless violence and community building to control central and northern Mexico.

Carteles Unidos: A union of drug trafficking and self-defense groups currently resisting the CJNG in the Michoacán area

Independent Cells: Dozens of cells engaged in local activities such as oil theft or drug dealing, often providing services to transnational organizations.

b) Local Gangs

Street gangs, outlaw motorcycle gangs (OMGs), and prison gangs are the primary distributors of illegal drugs on the streets. Gangs also smuggle drugs and produce and transport drugs within countries. Street gang members convert powdered cocaine into crack cocaine and produce most of the PCP available. Gangs, primarily OMGs, also produce marijuana and methamphetamine. In addition, gangs increasingly are involved in smuggling large quantities of cocaine and marijuana and lesser quantities of heroin, methamphetamine, and MDMA into countries from foreign sources of supply.

Large, nationally affiliated street gangs pose the greatest threat because they smuggle, produce, transport, and distribute large quantities of illicit drugs and are extremely violent. Local street gangs in rural, suburban, and urban areas pose a low but growing threat, transporting and distributing drugs within very specific areas. These gangs often imitate the larger, more powerful national gangs in order to gain respect from rivals. Some gangs collect millions of dollars per month selling illegal drugs, trafficking weapons, operating prostitution rings, and selling stolen property. Gangs launder proceeds by investing in real estate, recording studios, and construction companies, and also operate various cash-based businesses such as restaurants and other establishments in order to commingle drug proceeds with funds generated through legitimate commerce.

Large street gangs readily employ violence to control and expand drug distribution activities, targeting rival gangs and dealers who neglect or refuse to pay extortion fees. Gangs engage in an array of criminal activities including assault, extortion, homicide, money laundering, prostitution operations, robbery, and weapons trafficking. Research further indicates that gang members who sell drugs are significantly more violent than gang members that don't sell drugs and drug sellers that don't belong to gangs, and that an increase in neighborhood disadvantage intensifies the effect of gang membership on violence, especially among gang members that sell drugs.

c) Individual Freelance Traffickers across the Darknet

The Internet is becoming increasingly popular among individuals as a platform for trafficking synthetic drugs. Synthetic drugs are sold on social media, Clearnet websites and the darknet. Some of the key reasons for trafficking synthetic drugs online include greater anonymity through the use of anonymising technologies such as encryption, VPNs and proxies, which make it difficult to trace and identify perpetrators. The Internet also allows individuals to reach a wider customer base while facilitating anonymous communication between vendor and buyer, eliminating the need for face-to-face interaction. The internet also contains a considerable amount of harmful knowledge such as drug preparation manuals, methods for acquiring illegal precursor chemicals, and concealment procedures to avoid law enforcement detection.

Illicit goods and services are primarily purchased with cryptocurrency, a digital currency that utilizes cryptography for security reasons. Three features of cryptocurrency are essential for individual freelance traffickers operating on the darknet: it is decentralized, meaning the transfer of funds can be initiated without the involvement of traditional financial institutions; it is anonymous, as the public ledger of transactions contains only account numbers without any names or identifying information; and it is easily exchangeable through a large network of small dealers, ATMs, and exchange providers. Cryptomarkets are increasingly being used by individual traffickers to expand their operations by reaching customers all over the world. These cryptomarkets minimize the risks of violence and exposure to law enforcement that are present in offline drug trafficking.

Money laundering is also a critical component of individual darknet drug trafficking. Money laundering involves three stages: placement, layering, and integration. Money is laundered utilizing digital currency, prepaid credit and debit cards, gift cards, fake name or shell company bank accounts, and online gaming sites. Individual traffickers also utilize semi-automated cryptocurrency exchanges and decentralized peer-to-peer exchanges to launder criminal proceeds.

8. Mechanics of drug trafficking

a) Transportation methods

i. Maritime Trafficking

Maritime drug trafficking represents one of the most significant methods used by organized crime groups to transport illicit substances across borders. Approximately 70 to 80% of cocaine is at some point smuggled across the ocean, originating from South America. For the North American market, cocaine is typically transported from Colombia to Mexico or Central America by sea and then onwards by land to the United States and Canada. Cocaine is trafficked to Europe mostly by sea, often in container shipments. The Balkan route traverses the Islamic Republic of Iran, Turkey, Greece and Bulgaria across South-East Europe to the Western European market, with an annual market value of some $20 billion.

Shipping lanes are the superhighways of international commerce, accounting for 90 percent of the global cargo trade. However, this presents opportunities for transnational organized crime groups to transport prohibited drugs. Larger maritime consignments were often stored on board 'mother ships' and transported to shore by smaller vessels from the coast. Underwater smuggling operations often involve divers attaching so-called 'parasites'—large metal containers concealed beneath the waterline and filled with illicit substances—to the hulls of cargo ships.

The use of semi-submersible vessels or 'narco-subs' has become increasingly prevalent. The submarines are custom-made, ocean-going submersible vessels, manned by a crew of four, with enough cargo space for up to ten tons of cocaine and fuel tanks large enough for journeys of 3,200 km, equipped with satellite navigation systems. Fully Submersible Vessels (FSVs) are the most sophisticated type, capable of diving completely underwater, invisible to radar, and equipped with advanced GPS and navigation systems.

ii. Air and Land Transport

Air transport represents another major vector for drug trafficking. Synthetic drugs trafficked via commercial passenger flights are typically concealed within passenger luggage or on/in passengers' bodies. Smugglers also employ underground tunnels, ultralight aircraft and unmanned aircraft systems (UASs). Drug smugglers utilize subterranean, cross-border tunnels to move illicit drugs, with construction increasing in sophistication; tunnels may include ventilation, electricity, and railways.

According to the UNODC, only 2% of containers that travel around the world by air, sea, roads and railways are adequately inspected for the detection of illegal acts. Crime groups often conceal illicit merchandise beneath a false bottom inside the container of a legal shipment, primarily among food products, agricultural products, frozen fish, fertilizer and coffee. Drug traffickers are also using chemical camouflaging, involving complex chemical processes to hide cocaine by infusing it onto legal cargo; cocaine has been discovered in beeswax, plastics, herbs, charcoal and various liquids.

9. Global Impact and Socio-Economic Changes

a. Impact on Public Safety and Daily Life

Drug production, trafficking, and use continue to increase instability and inequality, while causing harm to people's health, safety and well-being. Organized crime groups are using the same routes for different illicit activities including the trafficking of drugs, arms and wildlife. The addicts are often the victims of a powerful and manipulative business. Drug trafficking is often associated with other forms of crime, such as money laundering or corruption. The vicious violence once confined to Latin America is now spreading to Western Europe as organized crime groups from the Western Balkans increase their influence over the net.

Large populations in many parts of the world turn to criminals who sponsor the drug trade because of inadequate state presence, dire poverty, and the situation leaves them with few or no legal alternatives to survive. The more the state is absent in the provision of legal jobs and public goods, including public safety, access to justice, health care and education, the more communities are influenceable to becoming dependent on criminal entities. As the illicit economy expands, the investigative capacity of the law enforcement and judicial processes decreases. Moreover, powerful traffickers frequently turn to violent means to deter and avoid prosecution, killing or bribing prosecutors, judges, as well as witnesses and journalists.

The countries of drug production and transit are some of the most affected by the trade, though countries receiving the illegally imported substances are also badly affected. Displaced, poor and migrant communities bear the brunt of this criminal activity and on occasion are forced to engage in illegal resource extraction for their survival, leading to civilians becoming drug users or falling into debt at the mercy of crime groups. The drug problem is deeply connected to organized crime, corruption, economic crime, and terrorism, and the recruitment of young people into the drug trade remains a growing concern as they are particularly vulnerable to synthetic drug use.

b. Impact on Tourism and International Image

Illegal drug trafficking directly affects tourism through border controls, visa policies, cruise security, destination reputation, and geopolitical stability. Countries labeled as dangerous often face travel warnings and long-term damage to their tourism economies. Industry leaders warn that if the situation isn't controlled, countries could lose their appeal as top tourist destinations, as violence related to drug trafficking increasingly affects tourists.

The growing association of destinations with drug trafficking and heightened security risks can have an irreversible effect on the tourism industry. If the security situation worsens or if destinations gains an unwanted reputation, tourists will inevitably choose other alternatives. This would directly impact the lives of local communities,

from hotel owners to tour guides, threatening the very stability that allows economic development to continue.

10. Key Challenges in Combating Trafficking

a. Corruption and Money Laundering

Corruption and organized crime are often intertwined, with corruption playing a crucial role in how organized crime groups operate and expand their criminal activities while avoiding punishment. Corruption enables criminal groups to smuggle illicit drugs, weapons, and wildlife across borders while avoiding detection and bypassing law enforcement. Corruption not only facilitates transnational organized crime but also allows criminal groups to infiltrate and weaken public administration in many countries, undermining governance structures, destabilizing institutions and, posing a serious threat to public order and security. Research on drug trafficking at the international level has revealed that weak law enforcement capacity and corruption are instrumental in keeping the illicit market resilient. Corruption has been found to exist all along the drug supply chain, from production and trafficking to distribution, and it affects a wide range of institutions: eradication teams, law enforcement agencies, the criminal justice system as well as the health sector.

Corrupt police officers protect traffickers by deliberately turning a blind eye to their activities or tipping them off about impending investigations. They were bribed or coerced by traffickers to ignore suspicious activities, release victims in custody, or provide falsified documentation. In some cases, corrupt officers are directly engaged in trafficking, abusing their positions of authority. Furthermore, they sometimes leak sensitive information about ongoing operations, obstruct investigations, or misuse their influence to hinder the efforts of honest law enforcement officials. A lack of accountability and impunity allows corrupt practices to persist, leading to an erosion of public trust and confidence in law enforcement. In narco-states, the overall description consists of illegal organisations that either produce, ship or sell drugs and hold a grip on legitimate institutions through force, bribery or blackmail.

Proceeds from drug trafficking are one of the largest sources of illicit funds or dirty money in need of money laundering. UNODC estimates that global money laundering accounts for approximately 2.7% of global GDP. Money laundering involves three stages: placement, layering, and integration. Money is laundered utilizing digital currency, prepaid credit and debit cards, gift cards, fake name or shell company bank accounts, and online gaming sites. Individual traffickers also utilize semi-automated cryptocurrency exchanges and decentralized peer-to-peer exchanges to launder criminal proceeds.

b. Border Security and Tracking Technologies

Most illegal drugs are smuggled through ports of entry, often mixed in with legal products and concealed in secret compartments, including vehicle gas tanks. Using modern sensors, border agents can detect contraband through minute changes in air pressure or the composition of gases emitted from a vehicle, container, or package. The latest generation of X-ray and gamma-ray scanners are highly effective in detecting contraband, though these scanners are

expensive and require extensive training for border agents to use them effectively. Recent technological advancements have produced a wide variety of biometric identification devices using physical characteristics to identify people crossing borders, including digital passports containing biometric data on embedded RFID chips, fingerprint readers, iris scanners, and networked cameras using facial recognition software backed by artificial intelligence.

OSINT — the collection and analysis of publicly available information — has become indispensable in helping border and law enforcement personnel identify potential threats, intercept illicit shipments, and dismantle trafficking networks. By layering OSINT data with existing cargo manifests and travel documents, agencies can more accurately assess which shipments or individuals warrant secondary inspection. Modern OSINT platforms include multilingual natural language processing that can monitor hundreds of languages and dialects — including regional slang and trafficking jargon — enabling agencies to stay ahead of codeword shifts and deception tactics used by cartels and intermediaries. OSINT investigations, despite their open aspect, must still be conducted in full compliance with human rights, privacy, proportionality, lawfulness, accountability, and necessity guidelines.

The strategic integration of AI and unmanned aircraft systems (UAS) offers superior enforcement against drug trafficking. Key developments include the use of drones and AI to identify wild-growing or cultivated areas of cannabis, opium poppy, and coca bushes, enhanced by hyperspectral imaging. AI and drones are also used for identifying synthetic drug labs, with gas emission sensors collecting crucial data for AI processing. Combining various sensors with drones and AI enables a broad range of surveillance tasks, from detecting synthetic drug labs to border security and smuggling prevention.

11. International Frameworks

a. Global Treaties

The Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs aimed to combat drug use through coordinated international intervention. It is intended to limit the possession, consumption, trade, distribution, import, export, manufacture and production of drugs only for medical and scientific purposes. The Convention on Psychotropic Substances of 1971 established an international control system for psychotropic substances. It responded to the diversification and expansion of the number of drugs giving rise to illicit use and set up controls on a number of synthetic drugs. The three major international drug control treaties are mutually supportive and complementary. The 1988 Convention extends the control regime to precursors, and focuses on establishing measures to combat illicit drug trafficking and related money-laundering, as well as strengthening the framework of international cooperation.

The United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime is the main international instrument in the fight against transnational organized crime. States that ratify this instrument commit themselves to taking a series of measures against transnational organized crime, including the creation of domestic criminal offences covering participation in an organized criminal group, money laundering, corruption and obstruction of justice; the adoption of new frameworks for extradition, mutual legal assistance and law enforcement cooperation; and the promotion of training and technical assistance for building or upgrading

the necessary capacity of national authorities. The Convention is further supplemented by three Protocols, which target specific areas and manifestations of organized crime: the Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons; the Protocol against the Smuggling of Migrants by Land, Sea and Air; and the Protocol against the Illicit Manufacturing of and Trafficking in Firearms.

UNTOC, also known as the Palermo Convention, is the only global, legally binding instrument through which governments commit to act and cooperate against organized crime. With 192 states parties, it is one of the world's most widely ratified conventions. One innovation of UNTOC is the range of measures it contains to enable and facilitate international cooperation, including extradition, joint investigations, mutual legal assistance and more. States meet every two years at the UNTOC Conference of Parties to improve their capacity to combat organized crime and review the implementation of UNTOC and to set the anti-crime agenda for the future.

b. Regional Approaches

i. The Americas

Central America and the Caribbean, particularly countries in the Northern Triangle, face extreme violence inflamed by transnational organized crime and drug trafficking. Criminal networks and their activities disrupt stability, undermine democratic institutions and hinder economic activity. After the Mexican government implemented its new national security strategy, it became more risky for traffickers to ship the drug directly to Mexico, and so an increasing share of the flow began to transit the landmass of Central America. These new paths traversed areas controlled by local organized crime groups, upsetting the balance of power between them. In a number of Central American countries, crime is the paramount public policy issue, deciding elections and changing the relationship between the people and their government.

Most of the countries in Central America have recently established special anti-narcotic and organized crime units within the police and the prosecuting authorities. The Santo Domingo Pact/SICA-UNODC Mechanism is an interregional programme which aims to enhance policy coordination in the field of drug trafficking and organized crime. The objectives are to facilitate the coordination of regional and national policies in the field of organized crime and drug trafficking, develop an analysis capacity of organized crime and drug trafficking trends, ensure an exchange of information amongst the partners of the mechanism and assist countries in implementing the UN conventions on organized crime and the three drugs conventions.

ii. Europe and the Balkan Route

The total value of illicit heroin and opium trafficked from Afghanistan to Western Europe through the Balkans amounts to some $28 billion every year. Sixty-five per cent of this total ($18 billion) is generated in Western and Central Europe. The four largest European markets

for heroin (France, the United Kingdom, Germany, and Italy) account for nearly half of the gross profits. Iran seizes about 30 per cent of the 155 tons of heroin and opium entering its territory every year, while Turkey seizes 17 per cent. All other countries in Europe intercept an average of six per cent of heroin in their territory. The large amounts of money generated through this illicit activity can distort the licit national economies in the region

The Balkan route is the most important heroin trafficking route to Western and Central Europe. Owing to border controls, network allegiances and risk analysis carried out by traffickers themselves, the Balkan route of heroin splits upon entering South-Eastern Europe into three branches. The northern branch traverses the Eastern Balkans. South-Eastern Europe is a crucial stage on one of the world's most important heroin trafficking routes, owing to its geographical position between Afghanistan, the world's most important opiate-producing country, and the large and lucrative markets for opiates in Western and Central Europe. South-Eastern Europe is also seeing an expansion in the trafficking of Albanian cannabis, with cannabis herb seizures in the region doubling.

iii. Asia

South Asia continues to face a multitude of drug related challenges exacerbated by its geographical location between the two main illicit opiates producing and trafficking regions of the world, namely the Golden Triangle and the Golden Crescent. South Asia remains a target for traffickers smuggling illicitly produced opiates from Afghanistan to Europe and North America along the alternate southern route. Coastal States in South Asia are vulnerable to maritime trafficking as a result of their exposure to trafficking routes across the Indian Ocean. A rising shift from trafficking in narcotic drugs to trafficking in synthetic drugs, including amphetamine type stimulants, and chemical precursors is reported.

The Golden Triangle, where the borders of Thailand, Myanmar, and Laos meet, is one of the biggest drug trafficking corridors in the world. The drugs manufactured here make it as far as the Pacific, New Zealand, Australia, and Japan. It requires that governments cooperate at various levels, especially frontline cooperation at the borders where the trafficking is taking place. This means sharing information and conducting joint operations to stop the delivery into Myanmar of chemicals needed to manufacture synthetic drugs. Organized crime groups look for chaos, the lack of governance, porous borders, and this they can find in parts of the Golden Triangle. Since 1999 UNODC has supported the establishment of over 120 Border Liaison Offices in Cambodia, China, Indonesia, Lao DPR, Myanmar, Thailand, and Vietnam with an estimated 3,000 officers working across the region.

12. Questions that a Resolution Paper Should Address

How can member states work together more effectively to combat the role of organized crime in drug trafficking?

How should member states respond to the growing threat of individual freelance traffickers operating across the darknet?

What actions can member states take to prevent organized crime groups from exploiting maritime, air, and land transport routes for drug trafficking?

How can member states combat corruption within law enforcement and government agencies that allows drug trafficking networks to operate freely?

What frameworks can member states adopt to detect and prevent money laundering of drug trafficking proceeds?

What steps can member states take to disrupt the operations of major cartels and drug trafficking syndicates?

How can member states improve border security while taking into account the capacity limitations faced by developing nations?

What can member states do to reduce the socio-economic vulnerabilities that make communities vulnerable to drug trafficking and organized crime?

How should member states protect individuals affected by drug addiction and individuals that are in danger as a consequence of organized drug trafficking networks?

How can member states ensure that regional cooperation mechanisms are effectively integrated to the global framework against drug trafficking?

How can member states address the increasing overlap between drug trafficking and other forms of organized crime?

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